JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 2: Government Services & Citizen Rights

Module 1 - Understanding the Indian Government

Module Overview

This handbook is your complete, beginner-to-advanced guide to **Understanding the Indian Government** — how power is structured across the Central, State, and Local levels, how the three branches of government work together, and how public services actually reach you. This is the first module in JanGyan's new category on Government Services & Citizen Rights, and it lays the foundation everything else in this category builds on.

By the end of this module, you will not need to search anywhere else to understand how India is governed, from Rashtrapati Bhavan down to your local Gram Panchayat or Municipal Corporation.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Describe India's three-tier structure of government: Central, State, and Local
- Explain the three branches of government and how they check and balance one another
- Identify the key roles and responsibilities at each level of government
- Understand how a public service or complaint actually flows through the system
- Know which level of government to approach for a given issue
- Recognise official government sources and avoid confusion with fraudulent ones

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Why This Topic Matters

India is the world's largest democracy, governed through a structure spanning **28 states and 8 Union Territories**, over **2.5 lakh Gram Panchayats**, thousands of Municipal bodies, and a Parliament representing over 1.4 billion citizens. Yet many citizens are unsure which level of government is actually responsible for the services that affect their daily lives — a pothole, a ration card, a birth certificate, or a national policy.

> *Reality Check: Many citizen grievances are delayed simply because they are sent to the wrong level of government — a municipal issue raised with a central ministry, or a state subject raised with a local body that has no authority over it.*

Understanding this structure isn't just civics knowledge — it's a practical skill that helps you get the right service, from the right office, the first time.

Introduction

India is described in Article 1 of the Constitution as **"a Union of States"** — a sovereign, socialist, secular, democratic republic with a parliamentary system of government. Power is organised in two important ways:

- **Vertically**, across three levels: **Central (Union) Government**, **State Government**, and **Local Government** (Panchayats in rural areas, Municipal bodies in urban areas)
- **Horizontally**, across three branches: the **Legislature** (which makes laws), the **Executive** (which implements them), and the **Judiciary** (which interprets them and ensures they are followed)

Every public service you interact with — a school, a hospital, a ration shop, a passport office, a road, a water connection — is delivered by one of these levels, operating within one of these branches.

Fundamental Concepts

The Three-Tier Structure of Government

Level	Head	Scope
Central (Union)	President (Head of State), Prime Minister (Head of Government)	National subjects: defence, foreign affairs, currency, railways
State	Governor (Head of State), Chief Minister (Head of Government)	State subjects: police, public health, agriculture, local government
Local	Sarpanch/Mukhiya (rural), Mayor/Chairperson (urban)	Local subjects: sanitation, local roads, water supply, property tax

The Three Branches of Government

Branch	Function	Key Bodies
Legislature	Makes laws	Parliament (Lok Sabha + Rajya Sabha) at the Centre; State Legislature (Vidhan Sabha, and Vidhan Parishad where it exists) at the State level
Executive	Implements and enforces laws	President, Prime Minister, Council of Ministers, civil services (Centre); Governor, Chief Minister, State Council of Ministers (State)
Judiciary	Interprets laws and delivers justice	Supreme Court, High Courts, subordinate/district courts

The Seventh Schedule: Who Makes Laws on What

The Constitution divides law-making subjects into three lists:

List	Examples	Who Legislates
Union List	Defence, foreign affairs, banking, railways	Parliament (Centre)
State List	Police, public health, agriculture, local government	State Legislature
Concurrent List	Education, forests, marriage, criminal law	Both Centre and State (Union law prevails in conflict)

Complete Detailed Explanation

Part A — Central (Union) Government

- **President:** The constitutional Head of State and the first citizen of India, elected indirectly by an electoral college; the role is largely ceremonial, with real executive power exercised by the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers.
- **Vice-President:** The second-highest constitutional office, who also serves as the ex-officio Chairman of the Rajya Sabha.
- **Prime Minister & Council of Ministers:** The real executive authority, responsible for governance, policy-making, and administration, and collectively responsible to the Lok Sabha.
- **Parliament:** India's Union Legislature, consisting of the **Lok Sabha** (House of the People, directly elected) and the **Rajya Sabha** (Council of States, representing the states).

Part B — State Government

- **Governor:** The constitutional Head of State at the state level, appointed by the President, performing a role similar to the President's at the Union level.
- **Chief Minister & Council of Ministers:** The real executive authority in a state, responsible to the State Legislative Assembly.
- **State Legislature:** Consists of the **Vidhan Sabha** (Legislative Assembly, present in every state) and, in a few states, a **Vidhan Parishad** (Legislative Council, the upper house).

Part C — Local Government

India's local governance runs through two parallel systems, both strengthened by constitutional amendments in 1992:

Panchayati Raj (Rural) — 73rd Constitutional Amendment

Tier	Level
Gram Panchayat	Village level
Panchayat Samiti (Block/Mandal Parishad)	Intermediate/block level
Zilla Parishad	District level

Urban Local Bodies — 74th Constitutional Amendment

Type	Applies To
Municipal Corporation	Large cities
Municipal Council (Nagar Palika)	Smaller cities and towns
Nagar Panchayat	Areas transitioning from rural to urban

Part D — Separation of Powers and Checks and Balances

No single branch of government has unchecked power:

- The **Legislature** makes laws, but the **Judiciary** can strike them down if they violate the Constitution.
- The **Executive** implements laws and policies, but remains accountable to the **Legislature**.
- The **Judiciary** interprets laws, but judges are appointed through processes involving the **Executive**, and courts cannot themselves make laws.

This mutual dependence — called **checks and balances** — prevents any one branch from becoming too powerful.

Part E — How Public Services Actually Work

A citizen's need typically flows through the level of government responsible for that specific subject:

- **Central subjects:** Passport, Income Tax, Railways, national schemes like PM-Kisan (policy and funding)
- **State subjects:** Police complaints, ration card, state-run hospitals, agriculture support
- **Local subjects:** Birth/death certificates, property tax, garbage collection, local roads and street lighting

Many national schemes are **designed centrally but implemented through state and local governments** — for example, funds and guidelines may come from a central ministry, while actual delivery happens through state departments and local bodies.

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
Federal Structure	Division of power between different levels of government
Legislature	The branch that makes laws (Parliament/State Legislature)
Executive	The branch that implements and enforces laws
Judiciary	The branch that interprets laws and delivers justice
Lok Sabha	The directly elected lower house of Parliament
Rajya Sabha	The upper house of Parliament, representing the states
Vidhan Sabha	A state's Legislative Assembly
Panchayati Raj	The three-tier system of rural local self-government
Gram Panchayat	The village-level unit of local self-government
Municipal Corporation	The urban local body governing a large city
Seventh Schedule	The part of the Constitution listing Union, State, and Concurrent subjects

Step-by-Step Understanding

How a Bill Becomes a Law (Central Level, Simplified)

1. A Bill is introduced in either the Lok Sabha or the Rajya Sabha
2. It is debated and voted on in that House
3. It moves to the other House for debate and approval
4. Once passed by both Houses, it is sent to the President for assent
5. On receiving Presidential assent, it becomes an Act (a law)

How to Identify Which Government Level Handles Your Issue

1. Ask: is this issue local (roads, sanitation, property tax)? → Approach your Gram Panchayat/Municipal body
2. Ask: is this a state subject (police, state hospitals, ration card)? → Approach the relevant state department
3. Ask: is this a national/central subject (passport, income tax, railways)? → Approach the relevant central ministry or portal
4. When unsure, start with your local representative or the National Government Services Portal for guidance

Real-Life Indian Examples

(General, well-established patterns described for educational awareness.)

- **Swachh Bharat Mission:** A centrally launched national mission, implemented largely through state governments and local bodies (Gram Panchayats and Municipal Corporations), showing how central policy translates into local action.
- **Ration Card Services:** Issued and managed at the state level, meaning the exact application process and portal differ from state to state, even though the broader Public Distribution System is a shared central-state responsibility.
- **Birth/Death Registration:** Handled entirely at the local body level (Municipal Corporation or Gram Panchayat), making it one of the clearest examples of a purely local government service.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario 1: There's a large pothole on your street that's been unfilled for weeks.
This is a local government responsibility — report it to your Municipal Corporation or Gram Panchayat, not a state or central office.

Scenario 2: You need to apply for a new passport.
Passports are a Central Government (Union List) subject — apply through the Ministry of External Affairs' official passport portal.

Scenario 3: You want to file a police complaint about a theft.
Police is a State List subject — approach your local state police station, not a central agency.

Scenario 4: You're unsure whether a scheme you heard about is run by the state or the centre.
Check the scheme's official website or ask your local representative — many schemes are centrally funded but state/locally implemented.

Government Rules / Guidelines

- **Ministry of Panchayati Raj:** Oversees the functioning and strengthening of rural local self-government institutions across India.
- **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs:** Oversees urban local governance frameworks and city-level service delivery.
- **MyGov & India.gov.in:** Official citizen-facing portals providing verified information on government structure, schemes, and services.

Laws & Policies

Law / Provision	What It Covers
Article 1, Constitution of India	Declares India a "Union of States"
Seventh Schedule	Divides law-making subjects into Union, State, and Concurrent Lists
Articles 74 & 75	Council of Ministers at the Union level, headed by the Prime Minister
Articles 163 & 164	Council of Ministers at the State level, headed by the Chief Minister
73rd Constitutional Amendment (1992)	Established the three-tier Panchayati Raj system for rural local government
74th Constitutional Amendment (1992)	Established Municipal Corporations, Councils, and Nagar Panchayats for urban local government
Article 124 & Article 214	Establish the Supreme Court and High Courts respectively

Important Statistics

Metric	Figure
States in India	28
Union Territories in India	8
Current President of India (as of 2026)	Droupadi Murmu, 15th President, since 25 July 2022
Current Prime Minister of India (as of 2026)	Narendra Modi, since 26 May 2014
Current Lok Sabha	18th Lok Sabha, constituted 4 June 2024
Panchayati Raj strengthened by	73rd Constitutional Amendment, 1992
Urban Local Bodies strengthened by	74th Constitutional Amendment, 1992

(Office-holder details are accurate as of 2026 and subject to change through future elections/appointments; always verify current holders on official government sources.)

Best Practices

- Identify whether your issue is a local, state, or central subject before approaching an office
- Use official government portals (.gov.in domains) to verify processes and requirements
- Know your local representative (Panchayat member, Corporator/Councillor, MLA, MP) and their role

- Approach the correct level of government first, rather than escalating straight to the top
- Keep acknowledgement numbers/receipts for any complaint or application filed with any government office

Common Mistakes

- Approaching the wrong level of government for a service (e.g., a local issue raised with a central ministry)
- Assuming all government schemes are run identically across every state
- Not knowing which representative or office is responsible for a specific concern
- Ignoring official government portals in favour of unofficial or unverified sources
- Expecting a purely local issue to be resolved by state or national authorities

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"The Prime Minister personally handles all government functions"	Real day-to-day administration is spread across ministries, states, and local bodies
"The President has the same powers as the Prime Minister"	The President's role is largely ceremonial; executive power rests with the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers
"All government schemes work the same way in every state"	Many centrally sponsored schemes are implemented differently across states, based on local rules and capacity
"Local government is less important than state or central government"	Local bodies deliver many of the services citizens interact with most often, like sanitation and local roads
"Courts can create new laws like Parliament does"	Courts interpret and apply laws; law-making is the Legislature's constitutional role

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Identify the correct government level before raising an issue	Don't send local issues directly to central ministries
Use official .gov.in portals to verify information	Don't rely on unverified social media posts about government schemes
Know your local representative and their responsibilities	Don't assume one office handles every kind of citizen service
Keep records of complaints/applications filed	Don't discard acknowledgement receipts or reference numbers
Approach local bodies first for local issues	Don't escalate prematurely without trying the correct first point of contact

Safety Tips

For Verifying Government Information

- Always check that a government website ends in the official `.gov.in` or `.nic.in` domain
- Be cautious of messages or calls claiming to be from "government officials" demanding money or personal details
- Cross-check any scheme or service through the relevant ministry's official website before applying

For Approaching the Right Office

- Ask local representatives or ward offices for guidance if you're unsure which level applies
- Use national portals like India.gov.in as a starting point for locating the correct department

For Families & Communities

- Share knowledge about which office handles common local issues (roads, water, sanitation)
- Encourage participation in local governance (Gram Sabha meetings, ward committee meetings) where available

Practical Checklist

- ☐ Know the three levels of government: Central, State, Local
- ☐ Know the three branches: Legislature, Executive, Judiciary
- ☐ Know my local representative (Panchayat member/Corporator, MLA, MP)
- ☐ Know which level handles common issues I might face (roads, ration card, passport)
- ☐ Bookmarked official portals like India.gov.in and MyGov
- ☐ Know how to verify a government website or scheme is genuine

Quick Revision Notes

- India has three levels of government: Central, State, and Local (Panchayats/Municipalities)
- Three branches: Legislature (makes laws), Executive (implements laws), Judiciary (interprets laws)
- The Seventh Schedule divides subjects into Union, State, and Concurrent Lists
- Panchayati Raj (73rd Amendment) and Urban Local Bodies (74th Amendment) govern local government
- India currently has 28 states and 8 Union Territories
- Many services are delivered locally even when policy originates centrally

Key Takeaways

1. Knowing which level of government handles your issue saves significant time and effort
2. The President/Governor are ceremonial heads; the PM/CM and their councils hold real executive power
3. Local government delivers many of the services citizens interact with most directly
4. Checks and balances between branches protect against any one part of government becoming too powerful
5. Verifying information through official .gov.in sources protects you from confusion and fraud

Glossary

- **Executive** — The branch of government that implements and enforces laws
- **Federal Structure** — Division of governing power across different levels
- **Gram Panchayat** — The village-level unit of rural local self-government
- **Judiciary** — The branch of government that interprets laws and delivers justice
- **Legislature** — The branch of government that makes laws
- **Lok Sabha** — The directly elected lower house of India's Parliament
- **Municipal Corporation** — The urban local body governing a large city
- **Panchayati Raj** — The three-tier system of rural local self-government
- **Rajya Sabha** — The upper house of India's Parliament, representing the states
- **Seventh Schedule** — The constitutional list dividing subjects among Union, State, and Concurrent Lists
- **Vidhan Sabha** — A state's Legislative Assembly

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What are the three levels of government in India?
Central (Union), State, and Local (Panchayats in rural areas, Municipal bodies in urban areas).

2. What are the three branches of government?
The Legislature (makes laws), the Executive (implements laws), and the Judiciary (interprets laws).

3. Who is the Head of State at the Central level?
The President of India.

4. Who holds real executive power at the Central level?
The Prime Minister and the Council of Ministers.

5. What is the Lok Sabha?
The directly elected lower house of India's Parliament, representing the people.

6. What is the Rajya Sabha?
The upper house of Parliament, representing the states.

7. Who is the Head of State at the State level?
The Governor, appointed by the President.

8. Who holds real executive power at the State level?
The Chief Minister and the State Council of Ministers.

9. What established the modern Panchayati Raj system?
The 73rd Constitutional Amendment, 1992.

10. What established modern urban local bodies?
The 74th Constitutional Amendment, 1992.

11. What are the three tiers of Panchayati Raj?
Gram Panchayat (village), Panchayat Samiti (block), and Zilla Parishad (district).

12. What are the three types of urban local bodies?
Municipal Corporation, Municipal Council, and Nagar Panchayat.

13. What is the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution?
The part of the Constitution dividing law-making subjects into Union, State, and Concurrent Lists.

14. Which level of government handles police matters?
The State Government — police is a State List subject.

15. Which level of government issues passports?
The Central Government, through the Ministry of External Affairs.

16. Which level of government handles birth/death registration?
Local government — Municipal Corporations or Gram Panchayats.

17. How many states and Union Territories does India currently have?
28 states and 8 Union Territories.

18. Can courts make new laws in India?
No — courts interpret and apply laws; law-making is the Legislature's role.

19. What does "checks and balances" mean?
A system where each branch of government has some ability to limit the power of the others.

20. Are all centrally sponsored schemes implemented identically everywhere?
No — implementation often varies by state, based on local rules and administrative capacity.

21. How can I verify if a government website is genuine?
Check that it uses an official `.gov.in` or `.nic.in` domain, and cross-check via known portals like India.gov.in.

22. Who should I contact for a local issue like a broken streetlight?
Your local Municipal Corporation or Gram Panchayat, not a state or central office.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Illustrations

(For JanGyan design team — placement suggestions only; no images generated here)

- **Three-tier government structure pyramid (Central → State → Local)** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Three branches of government wheel (Legislature/Executive/Judiciary)** → within "Fundamental Concepts"
- **Panchayati Raj vs Urban Local Body comparison chart** → within "Complete Detailed Explanation, Part C"
- **Flowchart: "Which Government Level Handles My Issue?"** → within "Step-by-Step Understanding"
- **How a Bill Becomes a Law visual flowchart** → within "Step-by-Step Understanding"

Official References

- Constitution of India — Articles 1, 74, 75, 124, 163, 164, 214, and the Seventh Schedule
- 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 — Panchayati Raj provisions
- 74th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 — Urban local body provisions
- Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Government of India
- Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India
- President of India — official website and public records
- Election Commission of India — Lok Sabha and Legislative Assembly records

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Official Government Website Links

- India.gov.in (National Portal): **https://www.india.gov.in**
- MyGov: **https://www.mygov.in**
- President of India: **https://www.presidentofindia.gov.in**
- Ministry of Panchayati Raj: **https://panchayat.gov.in**
- Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs: **https://mohua.gov.in**
- Parliament of India: **https://sansad.in**

Conclusion

Understanding how India's government is structured — across Central, State, and Local levels, and across the Legislature, Executive, and Judiciary — isn't just useful knowledge for exams or trivia. It's the foundation for engaging effectively with every public service you'll ever need, from a passport to a pothole repair. Knowing exactly which door to knock on saves time, reduces frustration, and makes you a more informed, empowered citizen.

This is the first step in your Government Services & Citizen Rights journey with JanGyan. Stay curious, stay informed, and remember: **the right service starts with knowing the right level of government to ask.**

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